

during one of her own interactions.

"When you're playing for the team's cause and you get dropped, it's tough. When on 49, I don't think of the single; I only look at the scoreboard and keep going. At that time, I contemplated leaving the game entirely.

"Papa was recovering from a heart attack, and my place in the team was in trouble. It's not easy when things go wrong with both your passion and your family. When I began training again, I wasn't feeling happy or confident about being back and had to grind that sadness out of me. The start of 2025 was easily the lowest point of my life. But you know the saying, right? *Sohne ko jitna ragdoge, utna shine karega* (gold shines better the more you polish it). I stayed low, kept the ifs and buts out, and focused only on myself and my game. God rewarded me by taking me to the World Cup."

Since November 2, the science of her measured 78-ball 87 in the WC final against South Africa has been dissected in enough detail. She revealed that she worked on curbing her aerial instincts early and opted for a risk-free approach to ensure she could make an impact for longer in the match. When Shafali remarkably found destiny calling her back to the Indian side for the knockouts, advice poured in from every quarter. But she chose to listen to the voice she trusted most — her own.

"Play with patience, play low, defend" — a lot of this came my way. Initially, I used to think, 'When I started, *sab badi wah wahi kar rahe the sab log ki arey wah kya chakke marti hai, kya karti hai.*' (When I started, people would marvel at my shots and how I played.) Eventually, I was honest with myself that if I wanted to grow my cricket, I needed to accept a few things, most importantly what wasn't working for me. I saw that when I played down the ground, I was getting out less frequently.

"I didn't listen to anyone else. I realised only I could help myself based on what I'd experienced. I went back and watched all my Test match innings and replayed them over and over in my head. I saw that grounding my shots came quite comfortably to me. If I could bring

that into my ODI game, it would help. That period between realising and implementing it was hard — I won't lie. But if you want to grow, you have to do what you have to do."

Since she broke onto the scene as a 15-year-old in the Women's T20 Challenge, Shafali has been known for her confidence, nonchalance and her ability to entertain the media with quirky one-liners. The side people don't see — and the one she has graciously bared following this tournament win — is the nervous Shafali.

"For me, nervousness is doubt — '*ab kya hoga, kaise karenge.*' The kind of low 2025 gave me, I hope that never happens again. But if it does, I will look back at this journey to pull myself up, because at that point I had nothing around me. I wasn't in the 15-member World Cup squad or even on the standby list. Ever since I can remember, people have said that only hard work is in your hands, nothing else. I never truly understood that phrase [until now]. Nothing teaches you better than experiencing it yourself. It's something I proudly tell others now."

The Women's Premier League has played a significant role in drilling many of these ideas into her game. In her now former opening partner at Delhi Capitals, Meg Lanning, Shafali found the yin to her yang — a calming presence who taught her how to be lethal without trying too hard. The auction has split the pair, though, with Lanning now at UP Warriorz.

"I will miss Meg a lot. Only I know how excited I was for the WPL because I would get to bat and learn from her. She was always keen to teach and motivate me, especially stressing the importance of singles in building an innings. Life is such that you watch people head somewhere else. But the Delhi Capitals unit for 2026 has some great foreign talent I'm excited to learn from."

There is plenty of unfinished business for Shafali, with Delhi Capitals having stumbled at the final hurdle in every edition so far. While she is eager to set that record straight, the more mature Shafali is now operating with a larger goal.

"*Badla lena hai* for the 2020 T20 World Cup final. That loss [to Australia] pinches me every single day. I cried very badly that day. When I went home, I saw the same thing running on television channels. It was already heavy on my heart, so I stopped watching TV. It really hurt for two or three days. That's life, you need to start all over again. So I did. I didn't understand it then; I was just a kid. But only I know how sad it is to feel like you've lost your passion for something you love this much."